language and ritual reflected this with a degree of precision.

The Zhou dynasty had already begun to codify these political and social norms and the elaborate rituals associated with them. There is the *Book of Change* , or the *Yi Jing* , which is the classic text for divination. There is the *Book of Songs* , or the *Shi Jing* , which is an anthology of poetry, both heroic and sacred. The Chronicles of the Early Zhou may be found in the *Shu Jing* , and in the *Book of Lord Shang* we have what Michael Woods calls the 'totalitarian manifesto'. [2] Dating from 340 BCE , it sets out a detailed administrative structure for the kingdom, including the division of society into counties, districts and villages, with a group of five families constituting the basic grassroots unit. It provided for, even at that early age, universal registration of the entire populace, from birth to death, necessitating an enormous and literate bureaucracy to maintain voluminous records. This penchant for record keeping and documentary archiving has remained embedded in every Chinese polity ever since.

When the Qin defeated the several Warring States and set up a centralized empire, this legacy of the Zhou was further expanded and refined. For example, uniform standards of weights and measures were introduced, as were strict laws and penalties for their violation. The ethical tradition of Confucius was supplemented by a Legalist tradition under the Qin, but the ruler remained at the centre of the state's power and authority.

~

In the Chinese historical narrative, one finds a deeply ingrained preference for strong and centralized political authority as an assurance of peace, order and social harmony. The periods of fragmentation, popular revolts against the state and internecine warfare are all associated with widespread chaos, economic distress and breakdown of the social fabric. The reality has been somewhat more complex, with some of these periods of turmoil also engendering extraordinary intellectual and cultural ferment. Confucius was himself the product of the age of the Warring States.

The Zhou dynasty later became romanticized as a kind of Chinese Ram Rajya, when concepts of a powerful ruler and a centralized state became